_ STEVENBOYLAN

THE FOUR GATES

What earns you the right to move from idea to product.

A SELF-ASSESSMENT GUIDE FOR PRODUCT TEAMS

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INTRODUCTION

Developing a product is rarely a straight line. It involves testing assumptions, changing direction and, occasionally, admitting that an idea simply doesn't work. Whether you're building a startup or launching a new product inside an established company, the goal is always the same: get in front of a paying customer and find out whether you've solved a real problem.

Most product teams go through broadly the same stages. What many teams don't have are decision points between those stages.

This guide introduces four gates for product builders. Each gate asks one question and requires enough evidence before you've earned the right to move on. The gates are not milestones. They are decision points. Passing is good. Failing is good. Going backwards is often the smartest decision you'll make.

The expensive mistake is not failing, it's *pretending* you've passed when you haven't.

Discovery	**MVP**	**Pilot**	**Productisation**
reduces market risk	reduces solution risk	reduces delivery risk	reduces commercial risk

The four questions

The guide is organised around four questions. You should only move on when you have enough evidence to answer the current one. If you can't answer the current question with evidence, you haven't earned the right to ask the next one.

01	**Discovery**	Does anyone care enough to act?
02	**MVP**	What is the smallest thing worth paying for?
03	**Pilot**	Does it create measurable value?
04	**Productisation**	Can we deliver this repeatedly?

The principle behind the Four Gates is simple:

Evidence − Uncertainty = Justified Investment

Each gate demands **more evidence**, removes a particular **uncertainty**, and therefore earns the right to make a **larger investment.**

That investment might be venture capital in a startup, or internal funding and resources in an established company.

Discovery → evidence of demand → invest in MVP
MVP → evidence of willingness to pay → invest in Pilot
Pilot → evidence of measurable value → invest in Productisation
Productisation → evidence of repeatability → invest in Scale

01

DISCOVERY

Does anyone care enough to act?

We all love free things. In fact, *free* is one of my favourite words. But how much value do we really place on something that costs us nothing? Usually very little. Plastic bags used to be free in supermarkets and people took them without thinking. They ended up stuffed into cupboards, used once and thrown away. Now that we pay for them, we think twice before taking one.

If you give something away for free, you are not measuring demand, you are measuring how many people are willing to accept free stuff.

The aim of Discovery is to find evidence that people care enough to act before you spend months or years building a product. Every idea sounds promising in a meeting, discovery is where you find out whether it survives contact with the market.

Engineers, founders and innovators are naturally drawn to interesting technology. Customers are struggling with problems worth solving. Discovery forces those two worlds to meet before you've invested months of time and hundreds of thousands of euros on a *solution in search of a problem*. I.e. discover whether a market exists before you build anything, not while you're building it.

Better to learn the answer for €500 than €500,000.

Payment is the cleanest signal, but at a very early stage "pay" can also mean an investment of someone's time or effort. What matters is that it costs them something, and they are willing to make that commitment because they believe your product is worth it.

How can I tell?

Some markets have long buying cycles and customers need time before they are ready to commit financially. That is why, although payment is the gold standard, it is not always practical when the product does not yet exist. That does not mean you abandon validation. It means you look for the strongest commitment that is realistic for your situation.

Whatever approach you choose, decide in advance what success looks like and write it down. Define the metric, define the threshold and, just as importantly, explain why you chose it. **The threshold is not there to kill your product, it is there to stop you grading your own homework.** If the result surprises you in either direction you can reset the threshold, on one condition: in writing, with the reason.

"We aimed for 2,000 signups, the category norm turns out to be 100, we got 200" is a recalibration.

"We got 3% against our 6% bar and decided 3% was fine" is an excuse. The difference is whether the evidence moved or your standards did.

One of the simplest ways to test an idea is with a landing page. Create a clear value proposition, drive a modest amount of traffic to it and measure what happens. Clicks tell you that people are curious. What they do next tells you whether they are committed. Do they leave immediately? Do they join a waiting list? Do they complete a survey? Better still, are they willing to pre-order or place a deposit?

A landing page is only one option. In many B2B markets, a handful of well-run customer interviews will tell you far more than thousands of anonymous website visitors. Calling, surveying and emailing potential customers can be enough, provided what you establish is that they have the **problem**, feel real **pressure** to solve it, and hold the **budget** to pay for a solution.

Remember: the objective is not to collect compliments but to collect evidence.

I have ended so many meetings as a founder thinking "this is amazing, they love our product" only to realise "we got no LOI, no pilot and ultimately no budget from the client". Compliments don't pay the bills.

By the end of Discovery you should be able to say, with reasonable confidence:

"We believe this group of customers has a problem worth solving and is willing to commit €X to solving it."

REAL WORLD FAILURE EXAMPLES

- The survey where 80% said they'd use the product. Live conversion was 4%. The survey measured politeness.
- The waitlist that grew for months and converted to nothing. Signing up cost nothing, so it proved nothing.
- The internal tool with three enthusiastic champions, none of whom held a budget.

The gate

Whatever evidence you choose to collect, decide what threshold you need before you begin. Otherwise you are not running a test, you are looking for reasons to continue.

Discovery is the cheapest point in the lifecycle to discover that an idea is wrong. That is not failure, it is exactly what the stage is designed to do!

EVIDENCE HIERARCHY

Gold standard: Pre-payment, deposits, paid reservations or customers paying to move to the front of a waiting list.

Strong evidence: Signed letters of intent, pilot agreements or senior decision-

makers investing significant time and organisational effort.

Useful but weaker: Waiting lists, newsletter subscriptions, completed surveys or qualified email sign-ups.

Not enough on their own: Clicks, likes, shares, positive comments or compliments.

↑ *not enough to proceed — go back and collect stronger evidence*

↓

Successful discovery earns the right to build an MVP.

02

MVP

What is the smallest thing worth paying for?

So you've determined that there is a market, they need a solution and they have budget to pay for it, let's get straight to building the product then?

Not so fast cowboy, we need to decide *what* we are going to build.

Customers describe problems well and design solutions badly. Product teams often do the opposite: they skip the problem and build the solution. There is an old joke that there are so many startups solving problems in Silicon Valley that there are no longer any problems in Silicon Valley. The MVP is not your product with fewer features. It is the smallest thing that allows a named customer to solve one valuable problem and decide it is worth paying for.

The purpose of an MVP isn't to save development time. It's to **reduce risk**.

Every feature you build before you know someone will pay for it is a gamble. The MVP exists to make the smallest possible bet.

How can I tell?

An MVP doesn't need to resemble the finished product. In fact, it can (and arguably should) have just one key feature. I.e. the key feature that the customer will pay for.

It can run slower than the final product, it can sit awkwardly between other products not ready to be fully integrated, it does not need to be fully automated – semi or manual is enough to prove someone will pay for it to solve their problem.

You don’t even need to have a product to get someone to say "I would pay X for that". However with today’s level of AI coding tools, putting together a demo software example is less than an afternoon’s work.

By now you should know exactly what problem you're solving. For example: converting Excel spreadsheets to PDF.

Today the customer wants to convert Excel spreadsheets into PDFs. Six months from now they might want AI summaries, SharePoint integration, automated workflows and twenty other features. These could in fact become important differentiators between you and your competitors... **further down the line**. But none of those matter until someone pays for the first problem to be solved.

For now, the client wants to convert Excel spreadsheets to PDF. Your question is: what is the simplest thing we could build that proves we can solve that problem?

That's your MVP.

You should be considering how to get that together as fast and as cheap as possible – shortcuts are your friend. Can you use an open-source library? Can you wrap an existing API? Can you perform part of the work manually? Can you fake the automation behind the scenes?

Long term, probably not. But long term only matters if you have customers. So right now, do what you can to get the MVP that the client is willing to pay for.

Every feature should justify its own existence. If removing a feature doesn't stop the customer buying, it doesn't belong in the MVP.

There is a popular startup adage, "Done is better than perfect". Whilst very true, this doesn't mean you should ship garbage. An MVP is allowed to be simple, it's not allowed to be broken.

REAL WORLD FAILURE EXAMPLES

- The six-month build that a two-week concierge test would have answered.
- The feature list taken from the loudest customer's solution, not their problem.
- The corporate MVP that took a year because it had to satisfy every stakeholder before meeting a single user.

The gate

THE MVP GATE IS SIMPLE

Can a named customer use your solution to solve a real problem, and are they still willing to pay for it?

Not enough on their own: A working demo nobody has committed to. Enthusiasm without a named buyer or a budget line.

↑ *not enough to proceed — find the buyer before building more*

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A successful MVP earns the right to run a Pilot.

03

PILOT

Does it create measurable value?

There is an old physics joke – yes, I'm that cool that I can cite physics jokes. The essence of the joke is that a farmer asks a physicist for help on his farm. The physicist disappears for a few days, returns with a mathematically perfect solution, and the farmer immediately complains that it doesn't work. The physicist replies that in order to solve the problem he had to simplify the model, so the solution definitely works... but only for *spherical cows in a vacuum*.

The MVP proved your product worked. The pilot proves it works in the real world. Those are not the same thing.

Joking aside, the pilot is a good point to test if you have built a real solution or a spherical cow. I.e. one that handles the complexities of a client's actual working situation, or a simplified model of a product that only works under tightly controlled conditions.

A pilot serves two purposes. First, it gives the customer confidence that your product works in their environment. Second, it gives you confidence that your product works outside yours.

A successful pilot also de-risks your sales process. You learn how your product behaves in the real world, where its limits are, what belongs on the roadmap and what customers actually need to deploy it successfully. It's also a great tool to show investors that your product is much more than an idea – especially if the pilot is paid for by the customer.

How can I tell?

The goal of a pilot is to prove that your product creates **measurable value** under **real operating conditions**.

A free pilot with no end date and no success metric is not a pilot. It's a hobby you're running inside someone else's company.

A pilot isn't a trial, it's an experiment. That is to say you should have a hypothesis that you can test, criteria that you can measure against and a real outcome so that you can decide if it was a failure or not. And remember, at this stage it can fail, and very visibly.

One of the most important factors in setting up a pilot is to decide what metrics it will be measured against. As with the discovery stage these should be decided in advance and should not be moved without real reason to do so – otherwise we're back to grading our own homework.

In setting up a pilot it's also important to find out who the stakeholders are. Most often it will come down to a financial controller, the MD, the CEO, the CFO etc. In this case it is important to make sure that you are collecting metrics that will impress this person.

If the outcome is: *"Employees enjoyed using the software."* then your pilot has failed because that isn't a business case. A CFO buys business outcomes: 15% lower costs, 20× higher throughput, 12 hours saved every week...

Those are numbers that justify a purchase. Anything other than a measurable outcome tied to a purchase decision will, at best, lead to several drawn out months of "we're not sure yet, the CFO isn't convinced of the value...".

Another important aspect of the pilot is that it should be time-bounded. Agree with the client beforehand the limitations of the test. These will vary from product to product, but for example:

- The test will run for a 4 week period where the product will be used 4h per day, 5 days a week, or
- The test will run for a 4 week period and will be limited to two users, etc.

Feedback is welcome, feature upgrades are not, otherwise the pilot becomes an endless consulting engagement instead of a buying decision. Feedback can and should be acted on at the end of the pilot when the client agrees to pay for the new features.

I have heard too many people running a lightly structured pilot with no agreed end date and constant update requests during this time. The pilot drags on indefinitely as the client is using it for free and therefore has very little incentive to start paying.

The only exception is when the customer says: "We'll buy it if it does this." If the request is small, get it in writing and build it. If the request fundamentally changes the product, you've probably found your next market rather than your first customer.

Before we finish, I've seen far too many founders undervalue their own time. They may be willing to work twenty hours a day to make their product succeed, but nobody else will. If your pilot only works because you're there twenty hours a day, you're not proving the product works. You're proving that you work. That isn't scalable.

SEEN IN THE WILD

- The free pilot that ran eighteen months, produced great engagement, and never a signature.
- The pilot judged on enthusiasm while the CFO waited for a number that never came.
- The pilot that succeeded because your best people were inside it every day, patching quietly.

The gate

The pilot gate asks one question: can your product create measurable business value under real operating conditions?

EVIDENCE HIERARCHY

Gold standard: Paid pilot measured against agreed business metrics (cost reduction, hours saved, throughput increased, revenue generated or errors reduced), with a commercial rollout or contract agreed if those targets are met.

Strong evidence: Pilot successfully meets agreed metrics. Executive sponsor validates the business case. Procurement or commercial negotiations are underway.

Useful but weaker: Strong user adoption, positive operational feedback, improving metrics that weren't agreed beforehand, customer requesting enhancements before rollout.

Not enough on their own: "The team loved it." High engagement. Endless feature requests. Pilots that never end. Founders manually keeping the system running.

↑ *not enough to proceed — renegotiate as a real pilot, stakes attached*



A successful pilot earns the right to Productise.

04

PRODUCTISATION

Can we deliver this repeatedly?

In the early days of computer vision, there was a story of an AI model trained to identify fish. It performed brilliantly on its training data but failed when tested on new images. When the researchers investigated, they discovered the problem: most of the training images showed people proudly holding the fish they had just caught. The model hadn't really learned to recognise fish. It had learned to recognise fish with human fingers wrapped around them. Presented with fish that weren't being held, its performance collapsed. This is known as **overfitting**.

Products can suffer from exactly the same problem.

A product that only works because your best engineers are constantly fixing issues, manually cleaning data or answering customer calls isn't really working. Like the fish model, it has become overfitted to the environment in which it was developed. The Productisation stage asks a simple question: **can this be delivered repeatedly, by ordinary people, under ordinary conditions?**

How can I tell?

Teams are naturally motivated to make a pilot succeed. A lot depends on it: funding, customer references and sometimes the future of the company itself. It is only natural that people throw everything they have at making it work.

The problem is that customers don't buy your best week. They buy your average Tuesday.

The Productisation stage is about understanding *why* the pilot succeeded. Was it because the product genuinely works, or because your team quietly filled the gaps?

Ask yourself some uncomfortable questions.

- Is the product only working because your engineers are manually fixing problems behind the scenes?
- Does it rely on perfectly clean, well-structured data that your customers won't actually have?
- Does it require your founders to answer support calls at midnight?
- Does every new customer require weeks of custom configuration?
- Does the product depend on a third-party data source or API that could disappear tomorrow?

If the answer to any of these is yes, you haven't built a product yet. You've built a successful pilot.

This is the stage where you remove those dependencies one by one. Every manual step should become automated. Every undocumented process should become repeatable. Every customer should require less effort than the last.

A product is something your company can deliver consistently, regardless of which customer is buying it or which employee is supporting it.

SEEN IN THE WILD

- Deployment two, run without the founding team, is where most "products" turn back into projects.
- Unit economics that only worked because heroics were free.
- The second product launched straight into build because "we know our market now." New product, new gates – back to 01.

The gate

The Productisation gate asks one question: can your business repeatedly deliver the same outcome to every customer without relying on exceptional effort?

EVIDENCE HIERARCHY

Gold standard: The product works even when you're on holiday. New customers can be onboarded through a documented, repeatable process with minimal customisation. Support requests are predictable and manageable. The product can be delivered profitably at the agreed price.

Strong evidence: Standard onboarding and deployment process documented. Multiple customers using the product successfully without founder involvement. Most issues resolved through the product or support documentation rather than engineering intervention. Customer implementations becoming faster over time.

Useful but weaker: Existing customers are happy, but each deployment still requires bespoke work. The founder or lead engineer is still heavily involved in onboarding. Manual workarounds exist but are well understood. The roadmap to remove these dependencies is clear.

Not enough on their own: "It works for our current customers." Every implementation feels like a new project. Customers depend on the founder to make the product work. Engineers are regularly patching problems behind the scenes.

↑ *not enough to proceed — new product, new gates: back to 01*

↓

A repeatable product earns the right to scale.



FOUR DECISIONS

If you answer Proceed four times in Part II, one of two things is true. You're at Productisation, or you graded generously.

There's a simple test for which. Give the worksheet, blank, to the person on your team most likely to disagree with you. Compare answers. The gap between them is the most accurate map of where you actually are.

Like any framework, this one becomes a hindrance the moment it is applied without thinking. The gates tell you what to prove, not how to prove it. What counts as evidence will differ by market and by product, and that is a judgement call. The one thing that does not flex is deciding what passing looks like before you run the test.

Your idea isn't worth anything until somebody pays for it, repeatedly, without you in the room.

Steven Boylan works with founders and product teams on exactly these decisions. The AI Clarity Sprint is the two-day version of this document, with the arguments included.

II

THE WORKSHEET

Name: _____ Date: _____

Fill this in without looking at anyone else's answers. Evidence only, not intentions. Then compare.

01 DISCOVERY — Talk is cheap: who pays?

YOUR EVIDENCE

Who paid, and with what? Money, committed time, signed intent. Not what they said.

YOUR THRESHOLD

The number you declared before testing. If you declared nothing, write nothing.

☐ **Proceed** ☐ **Test again, threshold declared first** ☐ **Stop**

02 MVP — The smallest thing someone will pay for is smaller than you think

YOUR EVIDENCE

Name the buyer. Name the budget it comes from.

WHAT THEY'RE ACTUALLY COMMITTING TO

Real conditions and real stakes, or a favour?

☐ **Proceed** ☐ **Find the buyer before building more** ☐ **Stop**

03 PILOT — A pilot is only real if it can fail

YOUR METRIC AND TARGET

The number, agreed in writing, before the pilot started.

THE END CONDITION

What was agreed to happen when the pilot ends?

☐ **Convert** ☐ **Renegotiate as a real pilot, stakes attached** ☐ **Stop**

04 PRODUCTISATION — It's not a product until it works without you

YOUR EVIDENCE

What ran without you, and what did it cost when effort was priced honestly?

RENEWAL AND REFERENCE

Did the first customer come back, and would they say so publicly?

☐ **Scale** ☐ **Second deployment first** ☐ **Back to 01**

THE FOUR GATES — ONE-PAGE CANVAS

The standalone version. Print it, hand it out, compare answers. *Name:* _____

01 DISCOVERY

Who paid, and with what? Against what pre-declared threshold?

☐ **Proceed** ☐ **Test again** ☐ **Stop**

02 MVP

Who is the named buyer, and which budget line commits them to real conditions?

☐ **Proceed** ☐ **Find the buyer** ☐ **Stop**

03 PILOT

What CFO-legible number was agreed before day one, and what happens at the end?

☐ **Convert** ☐ **Renegotiate** ☐ **Stop**

04 PRODUCT

What ran without you, and did the first customer renew?

☐ **Scale** ☐ **Second deployment first** ☐ **Back to 01**